

BUSINESS CASE	
Proposed Project	Expense Tracker
Date Produced	Sept 16, 2026
Background	A budget divides a person's available money into categories, such as rent, groceries, transportation and entertainment, with a spending limit for each one. Tracking expenses against these categories makes it easier to see how close a person is to exceeding a limit before it happens. Many students take full control of their own finances for the first time when they start university. They often manage student loans, part-time income, rent and groceries on a tight budget, and overspending in one area can quickly affect everything else. Budgeting on paper or in a spreadsheet takes discipline, and many popular budgeting apps are more complex than a student needs. This project proposes a simple expense tracker designed for students.
Business Need/ Opportunity	Budgeting is an important skill for students entering university, but it is easy to lose track of spending without a simple tool. Students need an application that allows them to: • Quickly record an expense with an amount, date and category. • Set a spending limit for each budget category. • See how much money remains in each category at any time. • Be warned when they are close to, or have gone over, a category limit. The tool should be simple, free to use, and keep personal financial data private, so that managing money does not add to the other stresses of becoming an adult.
Options	1. Develop an application that records expenses and displays them in a clear list. 2. Develop a budget expense tracker where each category has a designated spending limit. Each recorded expense reduces the remaining funds for its category, and the user is warned as a limit is approached or exceeded. 3. Use an existing budgeting app or spreadsheet instead of developing a new application. 4. Do nothing.
Cost-Benefit Analysis	

Option 1: Simple expense list

Costs: Low development effort, estimated at about 3 to 4 weeks. The main risk is low usefulness, since a list of expenses alone does not show whether the user is overspending.

Benefits: Quick to build and easy to use. However, a plain list of expenses does not show the user how much of their budget is left, so it does not fully meet the business need.

Option 2: Budget expense tracker

Costs: Higher development effort, estimated at about 6 to 8 weeks. Risks include scope creep and errors in the calculation of remaining funds and limit warnings, which must be managed through careful design and thorough testing.

Benefits: Fully meets the business need by showing the remaining funds in each category and warning users before they overspend.

Option 3: Use an existing app or spreadsheet

Costs: No development time. However, many budgeting apps require an account, show ads or charge subscription fees, and may share or store personal financial data on external servers. Spreadsheets require manual setup and formulas, which many students will not maintain.

Benefits: Immediately available and richer in features. However, it does not provide a simple tool that is focused on students and it might not be privacy-friendly.

Option 4: Do nothing

Costs: No time or money is required, but students continue to struggle to track their spending.

Benefits: None. This option does not address the business need at all.

Recommendation

Our group recommends Option 2, the budget expense tracker. Although it requires more time and resources than Option 1, the extra effort is justified because it fully meets the business need, fits within the two-month development period, and keeps users' financial data private and the tool free to use.